

« Spectator engagement arrangements have been increased manifold »

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Relegated to the margins of Indian sports for decades, Bihar is determined to make up for lost years in quick time. The state kicked off its first-ever major international competition with the women's hockey Asian Champions Trophy in 2024, followed by the Sepak Takraw World Cup earlier this year and then the Under-20 Asian Rugby. Up next is the all-important men's hockey Asia Cup at the massive Rajgir Sports Complex — the 90-acre project Bihar hopes will serve both as a nursery of talent and a symbol of its organisational abilities.

Leading the state's ambitions is Raveendran Sankaran, Director General of the Bihar State Sports Authority (BSSA) and the driving vision behind the transformation of the state's sporting landscape. He spoke to *Sportstar* on the BSSA's preparations for the Asia Cup and its long-term plans. Excerpts:

Can you give an idea of the planning, preparations and arrangements for the Asia Cup?

There are quite a few things,

especially after the ACT last year. One, we now have a second turf — it's ready and already in use — so we now have two floodlit turfs inside the same campus.

Two, we have upgraded all our athletes' and coaches' hostels, transit hostels and dining halls, and they are all now completely air-conditioned. Most of the technical officials, broadcasting teams and volunteers will be accommodated inside the complex itself.

Three, all the teams are being accommodated in Rajgir itself, within a maximum of 10–15 minutes' travel. Last time, as you know, the teams were put up in Gaya and had to travel every day. That won't happen now.

In fact, we had originally planned to host the teams inside the campus too, but the Indian junior men's team is there, as is the Indian Navy team. Plus, we don't yet have specialised chefs or separate dining halls for visiting countries. But wherever the teams are accommodated, we have instructed hoteliers to arrange chefs as required.

Four, every team has been

provided with the best facilities — a translator, security officer, liaison officer. Also, we have the Bihar Police Academy right across the road from the Sports Complex with a world-class gym and swimming pool, which will be open for them to use for workouts, swimming, rehab — whatever they need.

How easy or difficult was it to get it all done in less than a year? Last time when the women's ACT was held, things were still in process.

Not difficult at all. This was decided on the final day of the ACT and the Bihar government was very clear about meeting deadlines. We started work immediately, funds were provided and, most importantly, we had the Khelo India Youth Games (KIYG) in May. That not only helped us upgrade everything in time but also test the infrastructure and preparations on a massive scale.

What are the plans for the public in terms of facilities and arrangements?

Spectator engagement arrangements have been increased